

Nature walks put you on the trail of a good time

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There are plenty of great outdoor experiences in Western Pennsylvania, and not all of them involve sitting in a football stadium.

While there's nothing wrong with taking in a Steelers, Pitt or high-school gridiron clash, sometimes forgotten are the areas of sublime beauty that start in the city parks of Pittsburgh and fan out from there with the brilliance of a peacock's plumage

For this great date, it's a nature walk. No specific destination, no timetable, just a willingness to go outside and enjoy the many natural opportunities available in the region. We'll start with a guide, being more city dwellers than nature's children. Meet Chuck Tague, a nature photographer and writer, and president of the Wissahickon Nature Club.

Tague, of Mt. Washington, says that one of the best things about Western Pennsylvania is the many different types of natural wonders in any direction.

"You have the rivers coming from the south, so you see a lot of southern animals and plants moving up the Yough(iogheny) and Mon(ongahela) rivers," he says. "We have the Appalachians and the Alleghenies, we're in the foothills of that, so we have all the birds from the north. We do have the higher elevations of the Laurel Highlands, so we get birds and plants that are found much farther north. And we're right on the verge of the Ohio (River), what becomes the Great Plains, so we have a lot of Midwestern plants and animals."

Pick a direction, find a trail and then get started. but first and foremost, Tague says, be curious. He recommends purchasing a field guide; perhaps one written by David Allen Sibley, who has just published "The Sibley Guide to Trees" (Knopf, \$39.95) and is also the author of "The Sibley Guide to Birds." Tague says it's best to study a bit beforehand, to practice recognizing the basics -- even dandelions -- and then start.

"Just go out and enjoy yourself," Tague says. "You don't always have to know what you're looking at. But the more you know about it, the more interesting it is."

The Wissahickon Nature Club makes a point of choosing accessible trails in order to accommodate its members' needs; co-president Susanne Varley uses a motorized chair, and some of the club members are not of the age to do strenuous hiking. Thus, most get by in comfortable tennis or walking shoes. Those who prefer more challenging terrain might do well to purchase hiking boots.

Tague says it is wise to bring rain gear and to dress in layers, especially in September and October when cool mornings can still turn into warm afternoons.

Next, a pair of binoculars is a necessity, especially for those who want to go birdwatching. Tague's recommendation is "to spend as much as you can afford," with a minimum price of \$100. He also recommends shopping for binoculars at outdoor or sporting goods store, then ordering online at sites such as Eagleoptics.com where binoculars are sold at discounted prices.

Once on a trail, Tague notes there are differences between nature walks and birding ventures. As Tague says, "a wildflower is not going to run" away if there's noise. Birdwatching requires more patience and stealth.

"When someone spots a bird, everyone becomes very quiet and focused," he says.

For more information about the Wissahickon Nature Club call Tague at 412-488-8760, or Varley at 412-771-4737 or go [here](#).

WHERE TO GO

Chuck Tague, president of the Wissahickon Nature Club, lists areas for good nature walks in Western Pennsylvania

- Frick Park, Regent Square. Excellent place in the next month to watch for migrating birds.
- Beechwood Nature Reserve, Fox Chapel. Another good site to watch bird migration.
- Raccoon Creek State Park, Beaver County. Great spot to find fall wildflowers.
- Moraine State Park, Butler County. Especially good spot for nature walks as fall approaches.
- McConnells Mill State Park, Lawrence County. Another good spot during the fall.
- Jennings Environmental Education Center, Butler County. Offers a unique combination of prairie and forest, along
- Hillman State Park, Washington County. Used mostly as gameland during hunting season, the park offers numerous opportunities to view wildlife.

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